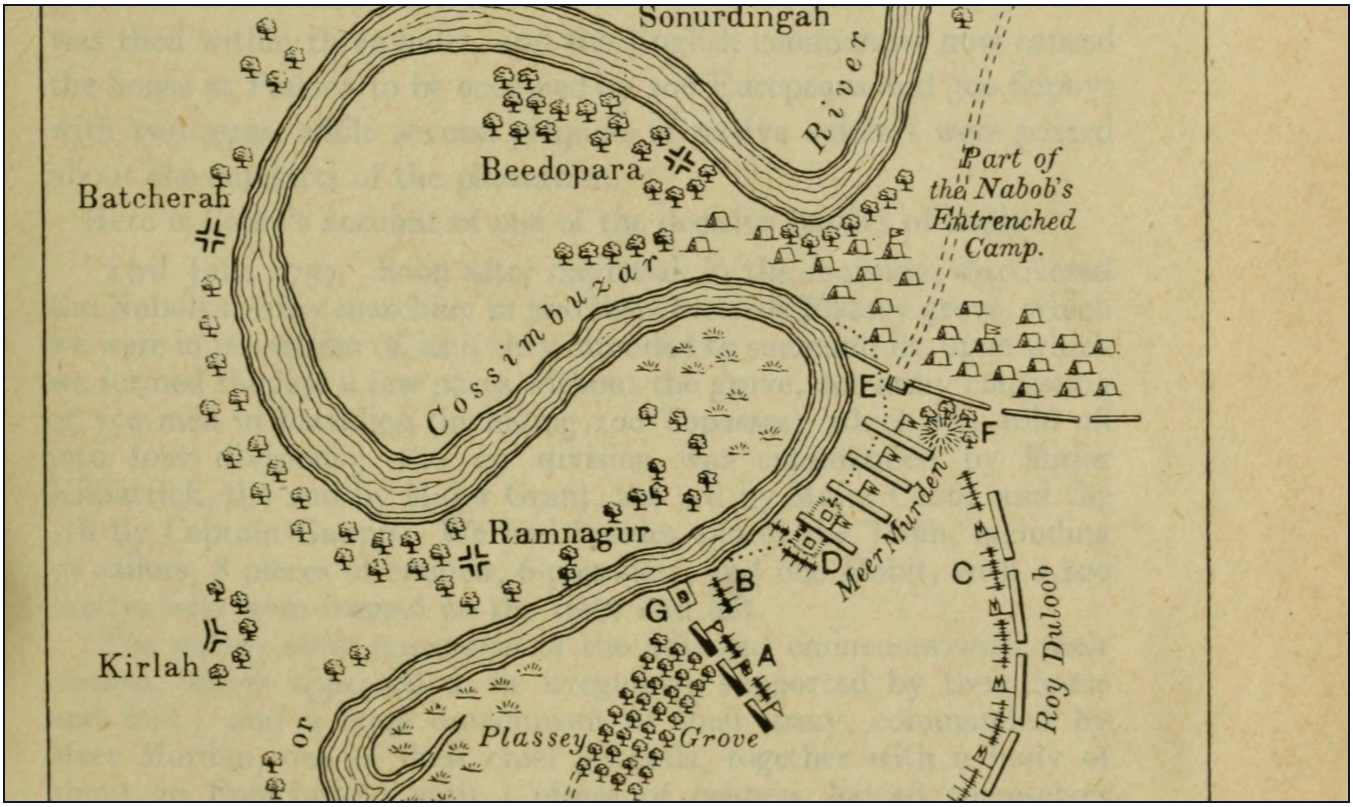
1600 – 1783

THE FIRST BRITISH EMPIRE

Mercantilism, Transatlantic Bondage & The American Revolution



Historical Painting (1765): Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II cedes the Diwani tax rights of Bengal to Lord Clive and the East India Company.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY • UNIT NARRATIVE SYNOPSIS 1600 – 1783

"From the founding of the East India Company and the horrors of the Transatlantic slave trade to Jamaican Maroon resistance and the American Revolution, explore how commercial greed, human exploitation, and colonial rebellion built and fractured the First British Empire."

THE CANONICAL ENQUIRIES • SCHEME OF LEARNING DIRECTORY **A3 SADDLE-STITCH FORMAT**

Enquiry 01	**The East India Company & Mughal Bengal**	*How did a private chartered trading company seize sovereign military control of Bengal?*	**Page 3**
Enquiry 02	**The Transatlantic Slave Trade & The Middle Passage**	*What were the economic mechanics and human horrors of the Triangular Trade?*	**Page 4**
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CORE CONCEPTS Charter Companies • East India Company • Jamestown 1607 • Mayflower • Indentured Servitude • Middle Passage • Chattel Slavery • Plantation Economy • Navigation Acts • Seven Years' War • Stamp Act • American Independence 1776

Chronological Turning Points Highway (1600–1783)

Twelve Decisive Causal Turning Points in the Rise and Fracture of Empire

31 Dec 1600

Royal Charter of the East India Company Ref [1.1]

Queen Elizabeth I grants a monopoly charter to London merchants, initiating corporate maritime commerce and factory construction in Mughal India.

1615–1619

Sir Thomas Roe's Embassy to Emperor Jahangir Ref [1.2]

King James I's ambassador secures Mughal farman decrees, granting European traders duty-free access and commercial security in Surat.

Aug 1619

First Enslaved Africans Land in Virginia Ref [2.1]

A privateer ship deposits twenty captive Angolans at Point Comfort, initiating chattel bondage in Britain's North American tobacco colonies.

May 1655

English Naval Conquest of Jamaica Ref [3.1]

Cromwell's "Western Design" seizes Jamaica from Spain, rapidly transforming the island into the epicenter of the brutal Atlantic sugar economy.

1672

Royal African Company Chartered Ref [2.2]

Led by James, Duke of York, the Crown establishes a corporate monopoly shipping more than 200,000 enslaved Africans across the Middle Passage.

1720–1739

First Maroon War & Queen Nanny's Treaty Ref [3.4–3.5]

Escaped Jamaican Maroons wage mountain guerrilla warfare, compelling British authorities to sign a 1739 treaty recognising their sovereign autonomy.

23 Jun 1757

Battle of Plassey & Corporate Rule in Bengal Ref [1.4]

Robert Clive defeats Nawab Siraj ud-Daulah through political betrayal, transforming the EIC from a trading concern into a sovereign territorial power.

Aug 1765

Treaty of Allahabad: Emperor Grants Diwani Tax Rights Ref [1.5]

Shah Alam II cedes Bengal's vast taxation revenues to Clive, enriching company nabobs while paving the way for catastrophic agrarian famine.

Oct 1763

Royal Proclamation of 1763 Ref [4.1]

King George III forbids colonial expansion west of the Appalachians, incensing land speculators and deepening colonial friction with Westminster.

16 Dec 1773

The Boston Tea Party & Coercive Acts Ref [4.4–4.5]

Sons of Liberty dump 342 chests of British tea into Boston Harbour, triggering draconian punitive laws that unify the Thirteen Colonies in resistance.

4 Jul 1776

American Declaration of Independence Ref [5.1–5.2]

Thomas Jefferson drafts the revolutionary declaration proclaiming universal liberty, while maintaining slavery and provoking imperial civil war.

1775–1783

Dunmore's Proclamation, Black Loyalists & Paris Treaty Ref [5.3–5.5]

Over 3,000 Black Loyalists earn freedom aiding the Crown before British capitulation at Yorktown compels Britain to recognise American independence.

ENQUIRY 01

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

The East India Company & Mughal Bengal (1600–1757)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION How did a private chartered trading company seize sovereign military control of Bengal?

[1.1] THE LONDON CHARTER & ELIZABETHAN MONOPOLY (1600–1615)

Why did Queen Elizabeth I grant a royal monopoly charter?

On New Year's Eve in 1600, Queen Elizabeth I granted an exclusive royal monopoly charter to 218 London merchants and City financiers. Seeking enormous fortunes in Asian spice markets, the syndicate pooled £68,000 to fit out armed ocean-going galleons loaded with silver bullion and English broadcloth.

Commanded by James Lancaster, their ships returned laden with precious pepper & cotton cargo, generating sensational private trade profits of over 300%. This commercial triumph laid the permanent corporate foundation of the **East India Company**.

[1.2] COASTAL FORTRESSES & MUGHAL FACTORIES (1615–1700)

How did the Company establish fortified coastal factories in India?

In 1615, King James I dispatched diplomat Sir Thomas Roe to negotiate with Mughal Emperor Jahangir at his royal court. Roe secured an imperial royal decree permitting English merchants to construct permanent fortified warehouses known as factories at the port of Surat.

Over the seventeenth century, the Company established vital commercial coastal enclaves across Surat, Madras, Calcutta, and Bombay. These bustling depots were defended by armed sepoy garrisons of recruited Indian infantry, transforming merchant warehouses into formidable corporate fortresses.

[1.3] THE STORM AT CALCUTTA & THE BLACK HOLE MYTH (1756)

Why did tensions erupt into crisis with Nawab Siraj ud-Daulah?

By 1756, the lush province of Bengal had become the Company's most lucrative trading territory. When British merchants began mounting heavy cannons around Fort William without permission, twenty-three-year-old Nawab Siraj ud-Daulah marched 50,000 soldiers against Calcutta to halt unauthorized fortifications.

Following the swift three-day siege of Fort William, captured British soldiers were locked overnight in the Black Hole dungeon guardroom, where dozens died of suffocation. British imperial accounts sensationalized the tragedy to whip up public fury for conquest.

[1.4] TREACHERY AT PLASSEY & MIR JAFAR'S BETRAYAL (JUNE 1757)

How did Robert Clive achieve victory at the Battle of Plassey?

In 1757, Lieutenant-Colonel Robert Clive arrived with troops to retake Calcutta. Realizing he was hopelessly outnumbered, Clive used secret gold bribes to corrupt Mir Jafar, commander of Bengal's army, promising him the Nawab's throne in return for betrayal.

On 23 June at Plassey, a heavy monsoon downpour soaked Siraj's exposed cannon gunpowder while Clive protected British powder under tarpaulins. Mir Jafar's treason ensured his divisions stood motionless, allowing British artillery to shatter Siraj's forces.

[1.5] THE TREATY OF ALLAHABAD & CORPORATE PLUNDER (1765–1770)

How did the 1765 Diwani transform a company into a sovereign ruler?

Following further military triumphs at Buxar, Clive forced defeated Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II to sign the 1765 Treaty of Allahabad. This granted the Company the *Diwani*: the sovereign right of collecting land revenue and taxes across Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa.

Corporate agents ruthlessly extracted millions from Indian peasants. When severe drought struck, unbending tax enforcement triggered the catastrophic 1770 Bengal famine, leading to the starvation of an estimated ten million people while Company profits soared.

ENQUIRY 02

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

The Transatlantic Slave Trade & The Middle Passage (1619–1807)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION What were the economic mechanics and human horrors of the Triangular Trade?

[2.1] THE TRIANGULAR ENGINE & COMMERCIAL CAPITAL (1619–1672)

How did the Triangular Trade connect Britain, Africa, and the Americas?

Britain's transatlantic empire was anchored in triangular trade. British merchant ships sailed from Liverpool and Bristol laden with manufactured guns & brass pans, iron bars, and textiles, exchanging these manufactured goods with coastal African elites for human beings.

Captains forced kidnapped African captives into ship holds, transporting survivors across the Atlantic into brutal plantation slavery. Ships then returned to Britain laden with raw plantation sugar, rum, tobacco, and cotton, enriching British merchants and banks.

[2.2] CAPTURE, BARRACOONS & THE ROYAL AFRICAN COMPANY (1672–1713)

How did royal monopolies and the Asiento expand British slaving?

In 1672, King Charles II chartered the Royal African Company, headed by his brother James, Duke of York. The Crown granted the enterprise a legal monopoly over British slave trafficking, constructing heavily armed forts along the West African coast.

Enslaved men, women, and children were branded hot iron RAC on their chests to signify corporate ownership. In 1713, Britain secured the Spanish Asiento contract, winning the exclusive right to supply Spanish American colonies with enslaved laborers.

[2.3] THE AGONY OF THE MIDDLE PASSAGE & SLAVE SHIP BROOKES (1713–1781)

What forensic conditions characterised the horrors of the Middle Passage?

The Middle Passage was an eight-week ocean crossing of calculated terror. Hundreds of African men, women, and children were packed chained on wooden shelves below deck, given less breathing room than a corpse in a coffin.

Locked tightly in iron shackles & collars, captives suffered agonizing seasickness and deadly dysentery & fevers in pitch-black, suffocating holds. Approximately one in six captive Africans died during the horrific crossing, their bodies callously tossed into the Atlantic Ocean.

[2.4] THE ZONG MASSACRE & CHATTEL SLAVERY (1781)

How did the Zong massacre expose the dehumanising logic of chattel slavery?

In November 1781, the cruelty of chattel slavery culminated in the Zong massacre. Running dangerously low on fresh drinking water due to navigational errors, Captain Luke Collingwood ordered sick enslaved captives murdered to preserve financial investments.

Over three days, Collingwood had 133 thrown overboard to drown in the Caribbean sea. When the ship owners filed a fraudulent insurance claim treating human lives as lost cargo, abolitionist Granville Sharp exposed the atrocity to the British public.

[2.5] OLAUDAH EQUIANO & THE AWAKENING CONSCIENCE (1788–1807)

How did the Brookes diagram and Equiano's voice ignite abolitionism?

During the late eighteenth century, British abolitionists launched a powerful moral campaign to awaken the public conscience. Activists printed thousands of copies of the famous Brookes ship diagram, visually exposing how human bodies were stowed like cargo in dark, airless holds.

Freed African author Olaudah Equiano published Equiano's bestselling book autobiography, recounting his enslavement and stirring national outrage. This relentless public pressure forced Parliament to pass the landmark Abolition Act of 1807, outlawing British slave trading.

ENQUIRY 03

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

Plantation Reality, Queen Nanny & Maroon Resistance (1655–1740)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION How did enslaved Africans actively resist colonial bondage in the Caribbean?

[3.1] CROMWELL'S WESTERN DESIGN & SEIZURE OF JAMAICA (1655)

How did Cromwell's conquest of Jamaica birth the Maroon communities?

In 1655, Oliver Cromwell dispatched an English expeditionary fleet on his ambitious Western Design invasion, seizing the Caribbean island of Jamaica from the Spanish Empire. Amid the chaos of battle, enslaved African workers seized the opportunity to break their chains by escaping to rainforests in the mountainous interior.

Known as the Maroons, these self-liberated communities constructed impenetrable Blue Mountain fortresses. There they established autonomous settlements, cultivating communal mountain crops and organizing disciplined military units to resist British colonial recapture.

[3.2] THE SUGAR INDUSTRIAL COMPLEX & THE GANG SYSTEM (1670–1730)

Why was sugar cultivation described as an agro-industrial death machine?

On Jamaican sugar estates, enslaved people endured brutal industrial discipline from dawn until dusk. In punishing tropical heat, field gangs toiled under the constant threat of overseer cowhide whips, while mill workers risked having hands crushed in heavy iron crushing rollers.

Work continued relentlessly for eighteen hours a day during intensive harvest seasons. Extreme exhaustion & brutality caused shocking mortality rates, forcing wealthy absentee British planters to import thousands of newly captured Africans annually to replace those who died.

[3.3] DAILY SABOTAGE, BOILING HOUSES & CULTURAL SURVIVAL (1680–1720)

How did enslaved labourers engage in daily sabotage and cultural survival?

Enslaved people fought back against dehumanisation through everyday sabotage and cultural solidarity. Field hands actively resisted plantation oppression by breaking tool handles, damaging boiling house copper cauldrons, working slowly, and feigning sudden sickness to disrupt sugar production.

In slave quarters, communities maintained West African spiritual rituals, herbal medicine, and songs of hope. Elders gathered families at night to recount Anansi trickster tales, celebrating how a small spider outwitted greedy, powerful predators through quick intellect.

[3.4] QUEEN NANNY & THE WINDWARD GUERRILLAS (1720–1734)

How did Queen Nanny lead the Windward Maroons to military victory?

In eastern Jamaica, the Windward Maroons were led by Queen Nanny, a legendary Asante warrior and spiritual leader. Nanny trained her forest fighters in living branch camouflage, concealing warriors so effectively with forest leaves that they appeared as natural mountain foliage.

Maroons coordinated swift military movements across misty ridges by sounding the abeng horn made from cow horns. Using devastating guerilla ambush tactics, Nanny's warriors repeatedly outmanoeuvred and routed heavily armed British military regiments.

[3.5] THE 1739 PEACE TREATY: TRIUMPH AND COMPROMISE (1739–1740)

Why was the 1739 Peace Treaty both a triumph and a painful compromise?

Exhausted by decades of humiliating jungle warfare, British Governor Edward Trelawny sent messengers carrying a British truce white flag in 1739. The resulting peace treaty formally granted the Maroons 1,500 sovereign acres of fertile mountain territory, acknowledging their freedom.

However, the treaty demanded a painful moral compromise: the Maroons agreed to assist British authorities by returning enslaved fugitives who escaped plantations. Despite this tragic concession, Maroon autonomy proved that organized resistance could humble the British Empire.

ENQUIRY 04

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

The Thirteen Colonies, The Proclamation of 1763 & The Boston Tea Party (1763–1773)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Why did imperial taxation drive American colonists from loyal British subjects to open rebellion?

[4.1] VICTORY & THE DEBT TRAP: THE 1763 PROCLAMATION (1763)

Why did British victory in the Seven Years' War create imperial conflict?

Victory in the Seven Years' War left Great Britain with an enormous £133m imperial war debt. Seeking to prevent costly frontier wars with Native American nations, King George III established the Proclamation Line of 1763, forbidding white settlement west of the Appalachian Mountains.

American colonists felt cheated of fertile land they had fought to secure. Resentment flared further when Parliament passed the Quartering Acts, forcing towns to provide standing army quartering for ten thousand British soldiers.

[4.2] THE STAMP ACT & "NO TAXATION WITHOUT REPRESENTATION" (1765–1766)

Why did the Stamp Act provoke the cry "No taxation without representation"?

In 1765, Parliament passed the controversial Stamp Act to raise colonial revenue, taxing legal documents, newspapers, pamphlets, and playing cards. Colonists reacted with furious outrage, declaring that taxation without representation in the British Parliament violated their historic rights as freeborn Englishmen.

The Sons of Liberty organized violent resistance, attacking stamp collectors, hanging royal officials in effigy, and burning tax offices. Widespread colonial import boycotts crippled British exports, forcing Parliament to repeal the hated stamp tax in 1766.

[4.3] BLOOD ON KING STREET: THE BOSTON MASSACRE (MARCH 1770)

How was the Boston Massacre transformed into revolutionary propaganda?

On 5 March 1770, simmering anger exploded on Boston's icy King Street. A hostile crowd surrounded a lone British sentry post, pelting arriving soldiers with snowballs, ice & oysters shells while daring redcoats to fire their loaded muskets.

In the confusion, panicked soldiers discharged their weapons, leaving five dead colonists on the cobbles, including Black sailor Crispus Attucks. Paul Revere's engraving sensationalized the clash as a premeditated British slaughter, galvanizing colonial fury against military occupation.

[4.4] THE 1773 TEA ACT & THE MONOPOLY THREAT (MAY 1773)

Why did the 1773 Tea Act provoke outrage even though it lowered tea prices?

In May 1773, Parliament passed the Tea Act to rescue the struggling East India Company, which held 18m pounds surplus tea unsold in London warehouses. The statute granted the corporation an East India Company monopoly to sell tea directly to American ports.

Although this lowered tea prices below smuggled Dutch imports, colonists recognized a dangerous constitutional trap. Bypassing local merchants and enforcing taxes without consent provoked unified resistance and harbour blockades across colonial seaports.

[4.5] 342 CHESTS IN THE HARBOUR: THE BOSTON TEA PARTY (DECEMBER 1773)

How did the Boston Tea Party shatter relations between Britain and America?

On the night of 16 December 1773, dozens of Sons of Liberty Mohawks disguised themselves with war paint and blankets, boarding three British tea ships in Boston harbour. In three disciplined hours, 342 chests smashed open emptied £10,000 of tea into the ocean.

King George III and Parliament retaliated ruthlessly by enacting the punitive Coercive Acts of 1774. The legislation shut Boston port and suspended Massachusetts government, driving the thirteen colonies toward open armed revolution.

ENQUIRY 05

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

The American Revolution, 1776 Declaration & The Black Loyalists (1775–1783)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION How did the ideals of the 1776 Revolution contrast with the reality of slavery and imperial defeat?

[5.1] THE SHOT HEARD 'ROUND THE WORLD: LEXINGTON & CONCORD (APRIL 1775)

How did Lexington, Concord, and Dunmore's Proclamation start the war?

In April 1775, British redcoats marched to seize colonial munitions at Concord. The famous Paul Revere midnight alarm warned town militias to mobilize, leading to an armed standoff at Lexington Green where someone fired the shot heard round the world.

As war spread, Virginia's royal governor issued Dunmore's freedom offer, promising emancipation to enslaved Black laborers who fled rebel plantations to bear arms for King George III, prompting thousands to join the British forces.

[5.2] THE 1776 DECLARATION & THE PARADOX OF LIBERTY (JULY 1776)

What central moral paradox lay at the heart of the 1776 Declaration?

In July 1776, the Continental Congress in Philadelphia met to adopt the Declaration of Independence. Drafting the historic text with Jefferson's eagle quill, Thomas Jefferson wrote the immortal words declaring that all men created equal with natural rights to life and liberty.

Yet the founding document concealed a profound moral hypocrisy: forty-one of the fifty-six slaveholder signatories personally owned enslaved humans, deliberately denying basic legal and human freedom to half a million African Americans across the colonies.

[5.3] THOMAS PAINE'S COMMON SENSE & THE GLOBAL ALLIANCE (1776–1778)

How did Saratoga and the French alliance turn the rebellion into a global war?

The decisive turning point arrived in October 1777 at Saratoga, where American continental forces triumphed by defeating General Burgoyne. This victory convinced King Louis XVI warships and French armies to enter the conflict as formal military allies of the American rebels.

The conflict transformed rapidly into a global war. Great Britain suffered severe sugar island divergence, compelled to divert vital warships away from North America to safeguard its fabulously lucrative Caribbean sugar colonies against French capture.

[5.4] SIEGE OF YORKTOWN & BRITISH SURRENDER (OCTOBER 1781)

How did French naval power force General Cornwallis to surrender at Yorktown?

In autumn 1781, British commander Lord Cornwallis marched into a peninsula trap at Yorktown, Virginia. George Washington's forces besieged the garrison by land, while French Admiral de Grasse Chesapeake blockade cut off all British naval reinforcements and rescue.

Trapped and relentlessly pounded by heavy artillery, Cornwallis surrendered eight thousand redcoats on 19 October 1781. As defeated British soldiers marched out to lay down their muskets, their military band famously played the melancholy ballad The World Turned Upside Down.

[5.5] THE TREATY OF PARIS & THE BLACK LOYALISTS (1783)

How did the Treaty of Paris and the Black Loyalists conclude the First Empire?

In September 1783, the American independence treaty signed at Paris recognized the United States as a sovereign republic. In New York, British commander Sir Guy Carleton protected three thousand Black Loyalists who had loyally served the British Crown during the war.

British military clerks registered their names into Book of Negroes ledgers, issuing freedom certificates that allowed families to board Nova Scotia evacuation ships, securing liberty in Canada and later founding Freetown in Sierra Leone.

MASTER DISCIPLINARY RETRIEVAL ENGINE

MASTER KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL QUIZ

Standard Recall Protocol: 25 core retrieval questions testing factual mastery across all five enquiries. Use for low-stakes weekly partner testing, silent memory flash-checks, or end-of-unit homework retrieval. (Answers verified in textbook narrative; zero answers printed.)

ENQUIRY 1: THE EAST INDIA COMPANY & MUGHAL BENGAL

Page 3 • Ref [1.1]–[1.5]

1. Which monarch granted the royal charter founding the East India Company on 31 December 1600?
2. What were fortified European trading posts called along the Indian coastline?
3. Which British commander led East India Company forces to victory at the Battle of Plassey in 1757?
4. What Mughal emperor granted the Company the Diwani (tax collection rights) in 1765?
5. What was the legal right to collect all land taxes across Bengal called?

ENQUIRY 2: THE TRANSATLANTIC SLAVE TRADE & MIDDLE PASSAGE

Page 4 • Ref [2.1]–[2.5]

1. What was the triangular trade system linking Britain, West Africa, and the Americas called?
2. What was the brutal, forced sea crossing of enslaved Africans across the Atlantic called?
3. Which English port city grew into the largest slave-trading port in Europe by 1795?
4. What famous 1788 diagram showed 454 enslaved human beings crammed into the lower decks of a ship?
5. Which formerly enslaved African published a bestselling 1789 autobiography describing the horrors of kidnapping and the slave ship hold?

ENQUIRY 3: PLANTATION REALITY & MAROON RESISTANCE

Page 5 • Ref [3.1]–[3.5]

1. Which Caribbean island was captured by Oliver Cromwell's navy from Spain in 1655?
2. What highly profitable crop was known as "White Gold" across Caribbean plantations?
3. What were self-liberated formerly enslaved Africans who founded free mountain communities called?
4. Which revered female spiritual and military leader commanded the Windward Maroons in the Blue Mountains?
5. In what year did the British Crown sign a peace treaty recognising Maroon independence in Jamaica?

ENQUIRY 4: THE THIRTEEN COLONIES & THE BOSTON TEA PARTY

Page 6 • Ref [4.1]–[4.5]

1. What 1763 royal boundary banned American colonists from settling west of the Appalachian Mountains?
2. What famous slogan expressed American colonial outrage at paying taxes without Members of Parliament?
3. What 1765 tax placed duties on legal deeds, newspapers, and playing cards in the American colonies?
4. On what date did British soldiers fire on a protesting crowd in Boston, killing five colonists?
5. How many chests of British East India Company tea were dumped into Boston Harbour on 16 December 1773?

ENQUIRY 5: THE AMERICAN REVOLUTION & BLACK LOYALISTS

Page 7 • Ref [5.1]–[5.5]

1. Where did the first armed clashes of the American Revolutionary War take place in April 1775?
2. Which Virginian plantation owner drafted the American Declaration of Independence in July 1776?
3. What British proclamation in November 1775 offered immediate freedom to enslaved people who escaped rebel masters to fight for the King?
4. At which 1781 siege did General Cornwallis surrender his British army, effectively ending the war?
5. What was the official naval ledger listing the names and physical descriptions of 3,000 Black Loyalists evacuated to Nova Scotia in 1783 called?

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